

McFarlin expected to step down as UTEP baseball coach

By MARK LEIBSON
Times Staff Writer

UTEP baseball coach Larry McFarlin is expected to submit his resignation to Athletic Director Jim Bowden in the next few days, according to Times' sources.

After replacing Andy Cohen two years ago, McFarlin predicted UTEP would win the Western Athletic Conference baseball championship.

That dream never materialized as McFarlin watched his teams win only one game in each of the last two conference races.



Larry McFarlin

McFarlin told his players after an 18-2 loss to Grand Canyon April 17 that this would be his last season. He mentioned the job was too demanding and interfered with his family life. He also said the low-paying position was not financially rewarding.

McFarlin refused comment about his resignation following Saturday's double-header against San Diego State.

Earlier in the season, he said his resignation would be handled through proper channels by allowing the university to make the official announcement.

It is uncertain whether McFarlin's resignation will become effective immediately or at the end of the month. When asked whether he would hit the recruiting trail now that the season is over, McFarlin said, "No. I'm going to let whoever the new man is be in charge of the recruiting. I've

lined up some players."

McFarlin has weathered a long series of headaches during his two seasons at the Miner helm. In 1979, the Miners were emotionally charged after defeating the University of Oklahoma in three of four games early in the season while upping their record to 8-2.

When WAC play began in early April, UTEP was 18-12 and 1-0 in WAC after defeating San Diego State 8-6 to open conference play. That was the last win in conference by the Miners until last Friday afternoon when UTEP beat the Aztecs 5-4 to snap a 34-game WAC losing streak, longest in the school's history.

The university did not officially hire McFarlin until late in the summer of '78, several months after Cohen had resigned and too late for McFarlin to recruit.

Yet, with the departure of Arizona

and Arizona State to the Pac 10, McFarlin felt UTEP could win the WAC.

McFarlin's first year at the helm ended with a 20-29 record and 1-15 WAC mark.

McFarlin then beefed up his pitching staff by recruiting six talented freshmen who needed a couple of years' experience at the college level before facing WAC competition.

McFarlin also had to recruit two outfielders, three infielders and a catcher to fill the void left by graduation. By increasing UTEP's schedule to 76 games, McFarlin felt his young team could get enough games under its belt before heading into WAC.

The Miners were forced to count on one senior, two JC transfers and the rest freshmen. The freshmen were impressive at times but lacked the stamina needed to pitch in the WAC.

There were continual problems which plagued the Miners off the field. As of May 5, the Campus Field was roped off and will soon become part of a new Business College. While at the rain-soaked Turquoise Tournament in Albuquerque, Dudley Field was declared by the city to be unplayable and needed several days' rest to heal from a heavy schedule.

UTEP's double-header between the Miners and rival New Mexico State was canceled April 31 for lack of a playing facility since the Campus Field had deteriorated to the point where McFarlin felt it was unsafe for play.

There were also problems on the field, including several heated arguments with some of his players during games. Saturday's season-ending double-

header with SDSU was yet another example. Since the Aztecs needed to catch an 11 p.m. flight back home, both McFarlin and San Diego coach Jim Dietz agreed that no inning would start after 9 p.m.

The Miners were leading 7-6 going into the bottom of the eighth with only a few minutes before 9 p.m., showing on the clock at Dudley Field. McFarlin told his batters to take their time at the plate so the ninth inning would not be played.

Contrary to McFarlin's orders, the first two batters swung at the first pitch and before the Miners knew it, there were three outs and two minutes remaining before 9 o'clock.

The Aztecs then scored three runs to even the score at 9-9 kill UTEP's hopes for victory.